

don't need a freezer and can be stored in containers in a cupboard.

Freezer cooking

Casseroles, appetizers, certain desserts, fun restaurant knockoffs, and dinner entrées galore can all be prepared ahead of time for the freezer. Spend some time recipe researching. You'll be amazed at the phenomenal ideas out there.

SHORTCUTS AND STRATEGIES

Without a few tricks up your sleeve, once-a-month cooking can be far too daunting for the rookie frugalite. I think I am pretty hard-core, and before I gave myself permission to honor my own style and family scheduling needs, this process nearly did me in. I thought if I was going to embrace this concept, I had to do it the way all the hard-core once-a-month folks did it or it was somehow not valid. Hogwash. Get in there, figure out what works for you, and streamline it in a way that makes sense for you and your family. Here are a few ideas to help get you started.

A mix-and-match approach to storage

Different containers work better or worse for different things, and while I would love to be one of those eco-

goddesses who can pull this system off with nothing but reused bread bags, it's just not realistic for me. Using a consistent yet varied selection of storage options helps me utilize the fruits of my bulk-cooking system.

Batch-size flexibility

While many people approach this from a perspective of family-sized meal storage, smaller portions are helpful for singles or families where scheduling may inhibit sit-down meals from time to time. Having a variety of stored batch sizes provides maximum flexibility.

Precision purchases of small appliances

While the right tools (or lack thereof) can make or break your OAMC experience, going nuts on the gadget front can really cut into the savings you are trying to achieve. Take the time to figure out your personal cooking style as well as what items you'll be making regularly. You'll be able to make much more informed decisions that way.

Assembly-line production

This is great for the packaging of your selected OAMC menus, but it can also work for the actual creation of the mixtures. Quiches and restaurant knockoff dips come to mind, as do several dry ingredient kit ideas. Give it a whirl.